The Rite of Cremating a Corpse

Śavasaṃgavidhi · Toh 1282 · Derge Tengyur
རྟ་སྲེག་པའི་ཆོ་ག

The Rite of Cremating a Corpse, known in Tibetan as Ro Sregpé Choga and given a Sanskrit title along the lines of Śavadāhavidhi, is a short ritual manual of the Hevajra cycle, catalogued as Toh 1282 in the Tengyur among the commentaries on the tantras. Drawing on the Vajra Tent Tantra and related scriptures, it sets out how a qualified vajra master conducts the funeral of a deceased master, practitioner or ordinary person, first through the meditation of the deity and then through the rite for the corpse itself. It describes washing and adorning the body, generating it as the deity, conferring the maṇḍala empowerments on the dead where appropriate, and burning the body in a specially built hearth as a pacifying fire offering to the fire god, with detailed mantras, offerings and recitations meant to purify the deceased and guide them to a pure realm. It closes with instructions for gathering the bones into stūpas after three days, and its colophon attributes the work to the great scholar Jñānagarbha.

In the language of India: śavasaṃgabidhiḥ. In the language of Tibet: The Rite of Cremating a Corpse.

Homage to glorious Hevajra.

Having bowed with a stainless mind
to perfect awakening, the great bliss,
relying on the Vajra Tent Tantra (Vajrapañjara) and others,
for the benefit of all sentient beings
I shall explain the Hevajra
rite of cremating a corpse.
In a charnel ground, on the bank of a river,
in a forest, by a waterfall, or in a hermitage,
a vajra master who has the proper marks,
who is steadfast and possesses the profound Dharma,
learned in every field of knowledge,
who has utterly crushed the root transgressions:
the mantra that he teaches
will be accomplished by the practitioner, O!
For this, first, by means of approach,
having come to know it according to the rite,

by the division into deity and corpse
it should be applied in two ways.
Of these, the rite of the deity is this:
one worships the guru, the vajra holder,
and performs the sevenfold purification.
Generating the mind set on awakening,
one meditates on the source of phenomena (dharmodaya).
Imagining the seat of the buddhas upon it,
one should meditate on the five awakenings.
First one imagines the Person, and then
emanates the circle of ḍākinīs.
The gandharva having fully entered,
there is falling, melting, and recollection;
he should be roused by the goddesses of the quarters.
Once roused, as the fruit arises,
the eyes and so forth, Delusion Vajra and so forth,
and the three vajras are set at the three places.
Having made the wisdom being enter,
empowerment is conferred by the eight consorts (vidyās).
The nectar too is tasted,
offerings are made by the eight goddesses,
and the leader of the circle is praised.
Thus with these six limbs,
one takes on divine pride with the six mantras.
Then too one contemplates for a moment,
and then the sign is to be marked.

Next, the rite of the corpse:
when the master passes away,
the deluded say, "He has died."
"Died" is a conceptual notion:
he has gone to a pure abode.
Or else, whether he will be born
in Sukhāvatī or in a pure abode,
this cremation determines.
From the end of one body it conveys him to the end of a body;
and all lesser sentient beings as well

go from a happy destiny to a happy destiny.
In that rite, first,
one washes the corpse with clean water mixed with fragrance,
anoints it with various scents,
and sets it in place, properly adorned with ornaments.
With the rite of expelling obstructors and generating it as the deity,
one blesses the sense sources and the three places,
and inserts the consciousness in the form of A.
By reciting the root mantra and the others properly,
all wrongdoing and obscurations are destroyed.
Having melted it into the mind of awakening,
one generates it again and properly arises.
One should make vast offerings of torma,
make aspirations, and abide in protection.
To recite the hundred syllable mantra
as many times as possible is praised.
Thus throughout the three sessions
one should recite to the measure of a hundred thousand.
That is the preliminary rite.
After that, the rite of the ground and the rest,
the maṇḍala rite, is to be performed properly.
For vajra masters,
a vajra and bell are given into the hand,
a crown is placed upon the head,
the vajra vows are given,
and entry into the maṇḍala is performed properly.
Having given the vase empowerments,
by the full application of the vajra hearth,
the funerary rite is taught to be performed.
For a practitioner too this is done in the same way.
For all ordinary sentient beings,
entry and empowerment are to be left out;
by the fire offering rite alone
the purification is to be thoroughly performed.

Now the rite of the fire offering. On one side of the maṇḍala one should build a cremation house. Having made a platform as large as one is able, in its center

one should make a round hearth for pacifying, filled to its mouth. It is dug down half a cubit, raised outward four finger breadths, and surrounded by a rim of four finger breadths. Leaving the outer four finger breadths of it, one draws a garland of lotuses. Inside the hearth the hand emblems of the principal deity are placed: a vajra in the center, a wheel in the east, a jewel in the south, a lotus in the west, and a sword in the north. They should be made eight finger breadths wide. On that, coated with white color, one stacks whatever wood is suitable, and lays the corpse there facing toward the maṇḍala.

The order for setting out the offering substances and the substances to be burned is this. To the left of the mantra practitioner one places a vessel for the welcoming water, of gold or the like, filled with water, and the vessel for the water for the feet. On the right side, within a copper basin filled with scented water, one places the sprinkling vessel (prokṣaṇa) with kuśa grass set in it. Likewise one places in vessels the flowers, the incense, the conch of scented water, and the rest. On the platform in front one should place a bowl for food offerings made of gold or the like. As it is said:

Flowers, incense, and likewise scent,
the conch of scent and the rest, are set on the right;
on the left, the mantra's vessel of welcoming water;
in front, the food bowl is placed.
The water for the feet is offered first,
then flowers, incense and so on in their order.
If one worships with the offerings of the graceful goddess and the others,
one becomes greatly fortunate.

Then, the order for setting out the substances to be burned: in front one should place the filling ladle and the pouring ladle, the special substance, sesame, and butter, the chief of the common substances. The other substances should be placed on the platform on the right side, according to what is available. As it is also said:

The filling ladle, the pouring ladle, the special substance,
and the chief of the common substances
are placed in front of the mantra practitioner;
the other substances, whatever is available,
are to be placed on the right in their order.

Then, having bathed oneself and put on ornaments, one purifies all the offerings and the rest with hūṃ. Holding the vajra in the right hand and touching it above all the vessels, one recites oṃ tpahūṃ, and having thereby cleared away all worldly conceptions, one imagines those very substances as excellent and stainless. The kindling sticks and the firewood are also to be taken as prescribed for pacifying. Then the master should complete the generation stage with its six limbs; if it is already clear from before, it may be omitted. Then one takes fire produced by friction or the like and kindles it by fanning. oṃ jvala jvala hūṃ phaṭ is the mantra for kindling the fire. oṃ vajrasatva āyuṣe svāhā is the mantra for spreading the kuśa grass. oṃ la hūṃ is the mantra for the purifying sprinkling.

Then one visualizes in the hearth a variegated lotus with eight petals, and there one generates Heruka with consort through the five awakenings. Those very deities melt like quicksilver through great passion, and from what remains each becomes a syllable, the two joined together. From the two syllables arise the fire god and his consort. He has three faces and six arms, a great belly, and a crown of matted locks, and he holds the sacrificial staff. With his first two hands he embraces a wisdom consort like himself. In his right hands he holds a gundhe and the sacrificial staff; in his left hands he holds a vase and a rosary. One imagines his body as white in color. At his heart, upon a variegated lotus, is a triangle of fire, and on his tongue one imagines a red raṃ. Thus, from the melting of the raṃ, one meditates on the fire god as the commitment being. Moreover, one visualizes him as one's own special deity, as it is said: "Visualizing the fire god, perfect in every way, adorned with fine ornaments, one should pour the burnt offerings into the place of his belly."

Then, with the seed syllable at one's own heart, one invites the wisdom being. To him, seated in the sky in front, one offers the purifying sprinkling and the welcoming water and pays homage. One invites him with the mantra oṃ asnaye mahātejā sarvakarmasādhaka kāruṇyakṛtva satvārtha asminsannihitva bhava and dissolves him so that the two are not two. Then one performs the sprinkling (prokṣaṇa) and the rest. Imagining the seed syllable of one's own deity upon the ladle, and joining the two elbows, one offers seven ladlefuls. The mantras are: oṃ asnaye hūṃ. oṃ sarvapāpaṃdahanavajāya vajrasatvasya sarvapāpaṃdahana svāhā. oṃ vajrapuṣṭaye svāhā. oṃ sarvasaṃpade svāhā. oṃ vajravijāya svāhā. oṃ mahāvegāya svāhā. oṃ mahābalāya svāhā. oṃ vajraghasmariye svāhā. oṃ vajra āyuṣe svāhā. oṃ vajra apratihatavajāñāya svāhā. oṃ vajrabodhithrakṣuya svāhā. oṃ patalāya

svāhā. oṃ kuberāya svāhā. oṃ sarvakarāya svāhā. oṃ sarvapāpaṃdahanavajāya sarvapāpaṃdahanāya svāhā. With these mantras one offers the substances to be burned, each in its order.

Then one should offer a hundred or a thousand ladlefuls of butter, filled and poured. Again, having made the purifying sprinkling, one offers the welcoming water with oṃ jaḥ hūṃ baṃ hoḥ khaṃ raṃ. With oṃ nirītihūṃ one offers water for rinsing the mouth. Then one worships with flowers and the rest, and with the offerings of the Graceful Goddess (Lāsyā) and the others. With oṃ vajragharbhe āḥ one takes up the bell; with oṃ mahāvajra hūṃ one should take up the vajra. Then one should praise the fire god and make the supplication for the great purpose, and so forth.

Then one purifies the hearth three times. At the heart of the fire god one imagines the maṇḍala arising from the respective heart mantras, and then one invites the wisdom beings as appropriate and requests them to be seated. Again one performs the purifying sprinkling and the rest. In the shrine room one smears the ground with cow dung, builds a square maṇḍala platform, marks it with white lines into two tiers of squares, and places one portion of torma in the center. The five offerings are also set out. The feast food is placed in one large vessel as a common share, and one large vessel is also filled with beer. Having set these down without lifting them, one should then offer butter in twenty-one ladlefuls. Then one offers the remaining substances in order, with one's own mantra or the mantra of the deity, and finally one again offers butter in a fire offering of one hundred and eight. Again one completes the purifying, the offerings and the rest.

Applying this to the situations that are to be purified:

For the vajra practitioner, the lowest, and the master,
the syllable raṃ, the deity's wrongdoing and all obscurations:
those burned with the secret mantra of a hundred syllables
should be recited a hundred or a thousand times.
For the vajra holder, the wrongdoing of one's own deity:
meditating thoroughly on the form of form,
this is the instruction of the purifying rite,
to be known through the means of the lineage.

Then, with dance gestures, one pays homage to the deities of the maṇḍala, requests them to depart with oṃ āḥ hūṃ muḥs, and makes aspirations. Having recited the hundred syllable mantra three times, one should worship

the fire god with whatever is left of the substances. Then one purifies and makes offerings, praises and the rest. Then again one purifies the fire and requests it to depart, saying:

Having accomplished my own aim and the aims of others,
you who eat the offerings, depart!
Having departed thus, come again when kindled at the proper time,
and grant me every accomplishment.

With this one requests him to depart. One imagines the commitment being as beyond any object of focus. Then one gathers the bones and makes a stūpa in order to benefit the deceased. As it is said:

Thus, when three days have passed,
the garland of bones is gathered;
having moistened it with scent and milk,
with that one should make stūpas.

By performing this fire offering rite,
whose qualities cannot be told in full,
through this heap of merit of mine
may those in misery become victors.

Composed by the master, the great scholar Jñānagarbha. The treatise on cremating a corpse is complete.

Translator's Notes

• The verse summary of the deity rite compresses the generation stage: "the five awakenings" are the fivefold manifest awakening; the gandharva entering, falling and melting describe the union of the deities and the descent of consciousness. The Tibetan "gnyi mug rdo rje" is read as an evident slip for "gti mug rdo rje," Delusion Vajra (Mohavajra), the first of the deities set on the sense faculties. The phrase describing the hearth as "filled to its mouth" (kha gang ba) is uncertain; it may instead be a measure of the hearth. "Funerary rite" renders 'du byed, here in its ritual sense of the rites performed for the dead (saṃskāra).
• "Gundhe" is left as written; its meaning as a hand implement of the fire god is uncertain. "Sacrificial staff" renders mchod phyir thogs, a term of uncertain sense. The verse on applying the rite to those to be purified is very compressed; "□□□" is read as an evident slip for "□□□□" (wrongdoing), and the overall sense is tentative. In the colophon, dbang du bya ba is taken in its sense of "a treatment concerning" cremation, not magnetizing.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.